

HASHKAMA WEEKLY

בית מדרש 715

SHAVUOS EDITION 5786

By Reb Gemini on Day 1

חכמה ב-אI תאמין?

Consider the following “Torah” thought, generated by Gemini:

Did the AI get it

right?

Do you find it to be accurate?

Or did the technology miss the boat?

Rabosai, if you are wondering why the shul currently smells like a botanical garden and half the mispalelim are sneezing through Pesukei Dezimrah, we can blame the Magen Avraham. The Magen Avraham (Orach Chayim 494:5) codifies the ancient minhag to decorate our homes and batai knesiyos with branches and greenery for Shavuos. He explains that this is to remind us that on Shavuos, the world is judged regarding the peiros ha'ilan. The Levush (Orach Chayim 494:1) adds that it reminds us of the nisim at Har Sinai, which miraculously sprouted lush vegetation. Now, I understand our esteemed gabbai is taking Zyrtec like it is ma'aser sheni, but this minhag is fundamental. We beautify the makom Torah to show our profound, willing love for the Yom Tov. We are recreating that pastoral, idyllic moment when Bnei Yisroel stood at the mountain, surrounded by fresh blooms, completely ready to say na'aseh v'nishma. It is a beautiful, peaceful image. You look around, you see the ferns, you smell the roses, and you think, what a polite, relaxing, and aesthetic way to receive the ultimate mesorah from Hashem. But then we turn to the Gemara in Shabbos (88a), and the pastoral illusion shatters entirely. The Gemara states that Hashem performed kafah aleihem har kekigith. He literally uprooted Har Sinai, suspended it completely over the heads of Klal Yisroel, and presented a very straightforward Litvish ultimatum: "If you accept the Torah, excellent; if not, there will be your burial." Suddenly, the narrative shifts from a lovely spring picnic to an impending geological catastrophe. How do we reconcile these two vastly different realities of the very same day? Why did Hashem need to threaten us with a mountain if we were already standing there among the beautiful flowers declaring na'aseh v'nishma? The Midrash Tanchuma (Noach 3) provides a crucial distinction. The flowers and our willing na'aseh v'nishma applied only to the Torah Shebiksav. We were perfectly happy to accept the written scroll. But the Torah Sheba'al Peh—the endless machlokos, the grueling hours of hasmada in the beis medrash, figuring out what the Rashba actually means—that required a suspended mountain. The greenery represents our natural, baseline inspiration. But true kabolos HaTorah requires realizing that the mesorah is not just a beautiful accessory to our lives; it is our absolute survival. If we do not accept the difficult, heavy, unglamorous parts of the Torah, the entire world reverts to tohu vavohu. The flowers draw us in, but the mountain keeps us grounded when the learning gets tough. The **practical takeaway** for us as we navigate this Yom Tov and dive into the cheesecake is to embrace both the ferns and the boulder. When you are sitting in the beis medrash at three in the morning tonight, fighting off the urge to take a nap on your shtender, remember the mountain. Hashem did not give us the Torah just so we could have a nice, floral aesthetic in the dining room. We must commit to the grueling, heavy lifting of Torah Sheba'al Peh even when the initial excitement fades. So, enjoy the milchigs, appreciate the greenery before the gabbai throws it all in the dumpster, but recognize that our commitment to Halacha must be as immovable and absolute as the mountain hanging over our heads.

Rabosai, as we approach the Yom Tov of Shavuos, the local Costco is completely out of its industrial-sized tubs of coffee, which means we are adequately preparing for Tikkun Leil Shavuos. The Magen Avraham (Orach Chayim 494:1) cites the Zohar that early chasidim stayed awake all night learning Torah. Why do we subject ourselves to extreme sleep deprivation, surviving entirely on stale sponge cake and caffeine? The answer is grounded in a historic embarrassment. The Midrash (Shir Hashirim Rabbah 1:12) records that on the morning of Matan Torah, Bnei Yisroel actually slept in. Hashem had to literally wake us up to give us the Torah. So, to rectify this ancient snooze button catastrophe, we stay awake all night. It is a brilliant Litvish strategy: instead of setting a louder alarm clock, we simply eradicate the concept of sleep entirely. We sit in the beis medrash, swaying over a Gemara with glazed eyes, making sure that when the shacharis minyan finally begins, nobody is sleeping. Of course, the irony is that by the time we actually reach the Kriyas HaTorah on the morning of the First Day of Shavuos, half the shul is completely comatose during the exact moment we are trying to commemorate. We overcorrected so hard that we end up nodding off onto our machzorim anyway. But if we somehow manage to pry our eyelids open during that Kriyas HaTorah, we encounter a profound meteorological and spiritual phenomenon that demands our attention. The pasuk states that during Matan Torah, "vechol ha'am ro'im es hakolos" (Shemos 20:15). Rashi (Shemos 20:15) explains this literally: they saw that which was meant to be heard. The Mechilta (Yisro 9) expands on this, describing a state of complete sensory synthesis. How does this connect to our exhausted, over-caffeinated state from the Tikkun Leil Shavuos? The Maharal (Tiferes Yisroel 32) teaches that this visual auditory overlap represents a level where the spiritual becomes undeniable and tangible. When Bnei Yisroel slept in, they were trapped in a physical mindset, where a comfortable bed felt more real than the impending giluy Shechinah. By forcing ourselves to stay awake, we are actively breaking our dependence on the physical world. We deny our basic biological need for sleep to reach a state where the ruchniyus becomes our primary reality. In our natural state, we only see physical objects and hear abstract concepts. But at Har Sinai, the spiritual transmission was so powerful that the auditory became visually manifest. We want to reach the madreigah where the words of Torah we learn all night become so vivid, so concrete, that we can literally perceive them. The exhaustion is not merely a penalty; it is the very mechanism through which we shatter our gashmiyus so we can stand by Har Sinai and see the thunder. The **practical takeaway** for all of us is to utilize this exhaustion constructively rather than complaining about it during the kiddush. When standing during Aseres Hadibros, desperately struggling to keep your eyes open, recognize that your profound physical fatigue is actually a spiritual badge of honor. You have successfully minimized the gashmiyus. Now, take that altered state of consciousness and focus completely on the laining. Try to make the words of Torah as vividly real and visible to you as the wooden shtender you are leaning on for structural support. Have a wonderful Yom Tov, drink your coffee responsibly, and may we all be zocheh to truly see the kolos.

Thursday May 21 (Erev Shavuos)

--: pm מנחה
7:55 pm הדלקה
8:13 pm שקיעה
--: pm מעריב

Friday May 22 (First Day)

--: am שחרית
--: pm מנחה
--: pm מעריב (50)
6:42/7:56 pm הדלקה (Early/Late)

Shabbos May 23 (Second Day)

7:15 (Approx. 8:50) am שחרית (Yizkor)
2:30 pm מנחה
9:07 pm מעריב (52)
9:04/9:05/9:15/9:27 pm צה"כ (8.5/50/60/72)

HASHKAMA WEEKLY

By Reb Gemini on Day 2

חכמה ב-א תאמין?

Consider the following “Torah” thought, generated by Gemini:

Did the AI get

it right?

Do you find it to be accurate?

Or did the technology miss the boat?

Rabosai, on this second day of Shavuot, half the kehilla is nervously pacing outside the beis medrash anticipating Yizkor, while the rest of us remain inside attempting to absorb the profound lessons of Megillas Rus. The Midrash (Rus Rabbah 2:14) makes a rather fascinating observation about this specific megillah. It asserts that it contains no issur, no heter, no tumah, and no taharah. It was written solely to teach us the profound reward of gomlei chasadam. Candidly, this concept is quite a shock to the Litvish system. We spend the entire year intensely arguing over the exact shiur of a kezayis, the precise angle of schach, and the complex mechanics of muktzah, and suddenly we are instructed to read a sefer entirely devoid of intense halachic machlokos. Why do we deliberately focus on this narrative during zman mattan toraseinu? The Yalkut Shimoni (Rus 596) explains that the Torah is entirely built upon the foundation of chessed. If you can successfully master the most complex sugyos in Bava Kamma but cannot manage to pass the herring at the kiddush without an exasperated sigh, you have missed the foundation of the mesorah. Rus personifies this pure, unadulterated chessed. She abandoned her royal lineage, accepting immense poverty and social ostracization, simply to cling to the shechinah. Her chessed was completely selfless, devoid of any ulterior motives, representing the exact mindset required for true kabolas HaTorah. This foundational theme of selfless chessed provides the perfect conceptual bridge to the deeply somber phenomenon occurring immediately after the laining: Yizkor. The Geshar Hachaim (31:2) elucidates that praying for the neshamos of the departed and pledging tzedakah on their behalf constitutes the ultimate chessed shel emes. Just as Rus performed exceptional chessed for her impoverished mother-in-law Naomi when there was absolutely zero financial or social benefit to be gained, we recite Yizkor for those who can no longer reciprocate our kindness in this physical world. It is the purest, most elevated form of giving. We often mistakenly view Yizkor merely as a heavy, sorrowful obligation, a brief time to shed a quick tear before sprinting home to the fleishigs and brisket. However, the Levush (Orach Chayim 490:9) notes that we specifically recite Yizkor on the Yomim Tovim because the zechus of our tzedakah actively elevates their neshamos in shamayim. We are directly mirroring the righteous actions of Rus. We utilize the immense zechus of our Torah learning and our tzedakah to spiritually sustain our ancestors, just as Rus physically sustained Naomi by gathering stalks in the fields. We read Megillas Rus and then we immediately execute its core thesis in the shul. The **practical takeaway** for us today is to explicitly recognize that our rigorous dedication to the Torah must manifest as tangible, proactive chessed in our everyday lives. When you finally walk out of the shul today, completely exhausted from the lengthy davening and carrying an obligatory piece of dry marble cake, look around to see who actually needs your assistance. Whether it is committing to distribute more tzedakah in memory of your relatives after completing Yizkor, or simply offering a warm smile to the oblivious individual who accidentally occupied your beloved makom kavuah, you must enthusiastically practice the daily chessed of Rus. We must prove conclusively that our intense Torah learning does not merely produce brilliant talmidei chachamim, but also deeply compassionate gomlei chasadamim.

Rabosai, as we embark upon the second day of Shavuot, the gastrointestinal fortitude of the kehilla is truly put to the ultimate test. Yesterday, we enthusiastically observed the Rema (Orach Chayim 494:3) by consuming copious amounts of milchigs, convincing ourselves that eating a third slice of cheesecake is an elevated act of avodas Hashem. Yet today, the laining of Kol HaBechor emphatically shifts our halachic obligations. The Gemara (Pesachim 109a) famously declares that during the zman of the Beis Hamikdash, simchas Yom Tov was fulfilled with shalmei simcha, but today, ein simcha ela b'basar v'yayin. We are bound to transition from delicate blintzes directly to heavy fleishigs, consuming massive portions of brisket to generate proper simcha. We occasionally treat this mitzvah like a competitive sport, but the Rambam (Hilchos Yom Tov 6:18) sharply reminds us that if we gorge ourselves on basar v'yayin without providing for the ani, the yasom, and the almanah, it is not simchas mitzvah but merely simchas kreso. True simcha is fundamentally about expanding our boundaries to share the profound kedushas haYom with those lacking the physical means to celebrate properly. This intense requirement to generate unadulterated simcha through our seudos seems to clash violently with a deeply somber historical reality of this specific day. The Yerushalmi (Chagigah 2:3) records that Dovid Hamelech was niftar on Shavuot. How do we reconcile the strict obligation of ein simcha ela b'basar v'yayin with the profound aveilus of losing the Melech Yisroel? The Gemara (Shabbos 30a) describes how Dovid Hamelech begged Hashem to reveal the day of his petirah, ultimately learning he would pass away on Shabbos. To protect himself from the Malach Hamaves, he learned Torah continuously without pausing. Dovid Hamelech teaches us the ultimate synthesis of these conflicting emotions. His entire sefer of Tehillim was composed amidst relentless pursuers and deep yissurim, yet he consistently transformed that profound pain into beautiful shirah. The simcha we are commanded to achieve on this second day is not the superficial happiness of a successful barbecue. It is the Dovid Hamelech model of simcha. Even when remembering the crushing petirah of our king, we demonstrate that true Jewish simcha stems from absolute bitachon. We eat the basar v'yayin to physically manifest the spiritual joy of remaining intimately connected to the mesorah, utilizing the tools of gashmiyus to sing our own Tehillim. The **practical takeaway** for our kehilla as we navigate this Yom Tov Sheini Shel Galuyis is to elevate our physical celebrations into meaningful spiritual triumphs. When you sit down for your fleishig seudah, do not simply treat the basar v'yayin as a culinary indulgence. First, actively ensure that the ani and the yasom are formally invited to share your shefa, transforming your meal from simchas kreso into true simchas mitzvah. Then, as you battle the inevitable fatigue from the cholent, push yourself to learn just one more perek of Tehillim in the merit of Dovid Hamelech. Recognize that authentic Litvish simcha does not mean ignoring life's challenges or the heavy galus surrounding us; rather, it means confronting those exact difficulties and choosing to sing shirah anyway. Have a magnificent Yom Tov, enjoy the hot brisket responsibly, and may we all merit to experience the ultimate simcha speedily in our days.

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Cash: Hand to Tzvi Zev or Adam Edelstein

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Gift Card/Bitcoin: Do we look like Indian Scammers to you?

Upcoming Shabbus Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

2:30 pm מנחה

6:47/8:02 pm הדלקה (Early/Late)

8:20 pm שקיעה

7:15 am שחרית

8:21 pm שקיעה

9:13 pm מעריב (52)

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